

CHEW LAND CLEARING

Central Texas Landowner Guide

Take Your Land Back

What cedar and brush actually do after you clear them — and how to pick the right treatment the first time.

Written for properties in Coryell, Bell, and Lampasas Counties.

Most of the money wasted on land clearing gets wasted before a machine ever reaches the gate. It gets spent on the wrong treatment for the vegetation, on weekend labor that made the job harder instead of easier, or on the assumption that clearing is something you buy one time.

This guide covers three things: which treatment fits which problem, how to prepare a property so the machine time you pay for is productive, and what actually happens to Central Texas ground in the years after it is opened. Everything here is sourced. Where the research is genuinely mixed, this guide says so rather than picking the version that sells more hours.

One note on scope. This is educational material, not an engineering, ecological, legal, or prescribed-fire plan. Vegetation, soil, slope, access, and wildlife conditions vary property to property and sometimes acre to acre. Every job gets walked before a method is selected.

THE SHORT VERSION

Brush hogging maintains open ground. Forestry mulching reclaims ground that woody vegetation has taken over. They are not competing quotes for the same job.

Ashe juniper does not resprout when it is properly severed. It comes back from seed, and Texas Parks and Wildlife puts general retreatment in parts of the Hill Country at roughly seven to eight years [1].

Do not cut and pile brush before the mulcher arrives. Coordinate first, cut second.

Mature juniper-oak woodland in these three counties is habitat for a federally endangered species. Clearing it is a decision with legal exposure, not just a cost.

01 Start with the finish, not the equipment

The most expensive estimating mistake is not price. It is that nobody defined the end state in terms anyone can measure. "Clean it up" and "get the cedar out" are not scopes. Two contractors can bid the same acreage honestly and produce completely different properties.

Before you request a quote, define the result in numbers:

- Intended use — pasture, homesite, trail, fence access, hunting lanes, build pad, or defensible space.
- Trail or corridor width, in feet.
- Percentage of canopy to retain, and which specific trees stay.
- Maximum stem diameter you expect processed, and what happens to anything larger.

- Acceptable residue — how much mulch on the ground, and where it must not be concentrated.
- Areas excluded entirely.

That list costs you nothing and changes the quality of every bid you get. It is also the difference between a change order and an argument.

02 Know which cedar you actually have

Around here "cedar" covers more than one plant, and the difference determines whether cutting it works.

Ashe juniper

Ashe juniper (*Juniperus ashei*), also called blueberry juniper, is the dominant species across the eastern and central Hill Country and through most of this service area. It is a non-resprouting evergreen, usually multi-stemmed, branching near the base [2][3]. When it is completely severed at or below ground level — below the lowest living branches — that individual tree is finished. It will not come back from the stump [1][2][4].

Two details matter more than most landowners realize. Ashe juniper is dioecious: male and female plants are separate, and only the females produce the small purple berry-like cones that carry seed, maturing roughly eight months after pollination [3]. If you retain mature cedar for privacy or shade, you may be retaining a seed source — which is a legitimate tradeoff, but it should be a deliberate one.

Second, seedlings do not look like the parent tree. Mature foliage is scale-like, roughly two millimeters long and pressed tight to the shoot. Leaves on young shoots and seedlings are spiny and awl-shaped and can reach about half an inch [3]. That is the single most useful identification fact in this guide, because it is what lets you find a two-inch cedar in a stand of grass during your annual walk.

Redberry juniper

Redberry juniper (*Juniperus pinchotii*) is more common toward the western Hill Country. It resprouts from the root system after the tree is cut, which means mechanical treatment alone does not kill it and it requires more frequent intervention or a different control strategy entirely [1].

WHY THIS MATTERS AT THE WESTERN EDGE OF THE SERVICE AREA

If your property carries redberry juniper rather than Ashe juniper, everything in Section 05 about "cut it and it is done" does not apply to those plants. Species gets confirmed on the site walk before any regrowth expectation is set in writing.

03 Which treatment do you actually need

These two machines are solving different problems. A rotary cutter — a brush hog — is a heavy-duty mower. It cuts grass, weeds, and light brush and leaves the material on the surface. A forestry mulcher uses a high-speed drum or rotor with teeth to cut, grind, and redistribute standing woody vegetation in one pass [5][6].

Manufacturer capacity ratings vary substantially, and some heavy-duty rotary cutters are rated for woody material several inches in diameter. Rated capacity is not the same thing as productivity or finish quality in dense timber. A cutter that can survive a three-inch stem is not the same as a machine that will leave you walkable ground.

Decision factor	Brush hogging	Forestry mulching
Best starting condition	Open or previously cleared land — grass, weeds, scattered light brush	Dense woody brush, cedar, mesquite, saplings, neglected or inaccessible acreage
Primary purpose	Routine maintenance and height reduction	Initial reclamation, access creation, selective clearing
Residue left behind	Cut stems and longer material on the surface	Woody material shredded into smaller fragments and distributed
Ground visibility	Limited improvement if dense woody stems remain	Often substantially improved as understory is processed
Stumps	Cut stems can remain prominent and sharp depending on height	Can reduce stems lower and process residual material — but this is not stump excavation
Repeat frequency	Recurring seasonal or annual maintenance	Initial reset, then lighter maintenance
Cost of applying it wrong	Blade and deck damage, poor finish, repeated passes, unsafe debris discharge	Higher hourly rate, tooth wear, hidden-object damage, excessive mulch concentration

Choose by the end state

- **Maintaining pasture after woody vegetation is already controlled** — brush hogging.
- **Reclaiming acreage that has become a cedar thicket** — forestry mulching.
- **Cutting trails through dense brush** — mulching, for visibility and directional control.
- **Annual mowing around a homesite** — brush hogging, if rock and slope allow safe operation.
- **Selective clearing around mature oaks** — mulching can be more precise, but operator skill and root-zone protection decide the outcome.
- **Preparing a finished construction pad** — neither attachment alone. That requires survey, excavation, compaction, and drainage design.

The false economy of the hourly rate

A brush hog has a lower hourly cost. That does not make it the lower-cost project. Total cost is the hourly rate multiplied by productive hours, plus repeat passes, cleanup, follow-up work, and the odds that the finished result still does not meet the objective. The reverse is also true: a mulcher on open grass is unnecessary wear and unnecessary money.

THE REAL COST EQUATION

Total project cost = mobilization + machine hours + support equipment + disposal or follow-up + restoration + risk allowance.

Comparing hourly rates alone hides every variable that actually decides the number.

We run both approaches depending on the job, and we will tell you straight which one fits. We are not going to sell you a mulcher when a mower would have done it.

04 Do not cut and pile before the mulcher arrives

This is the most common and most expensive form of help we see. You have scheduled the machine, so you spend two weekends with a chainsaw dropping cedar and stacking it into neat piles, figuring you have saved yourself machine time.

You have usually done the opposite.

A mulching head is designed to process standing vegetation as one controlled sequence: approach the plant, sever or grind it, manage where it moves, reduce it to a target particle size, and place the material where it serves the objective [5][6]. Standing material is predictable. The operator controls the feed rate. Piles remove most of that control and turn a one-step treatment into a sorting, repositioning, and reprocessing job.

The cost driver is not how much brush exists. It is how many times the machine has to touch, move, sort, and reprocess it.

Site condition	What the operator has to do	Effect on the job
Standing brush	Inspect, engage, mulch, distribute	Fewest touches, best visibility, most predictable production
Loose cut material	Gather, orient, hold, mulch	More travel and double handling
Dense brush pile	Open the pile, inspect, separate, reposition, mulch	Highest uncertainty and highest hazard exposure
Pile mixed with soil or debris	Sort or remove contaminants before processing	Delay, added equipment, or material excluded from scope

What piles hide

Teeth, holders, rotor components, hoses, hydraulics, guarding, and the carrier machine itself are all in severe service. A pile can conceal:

- Barbed wire, woven fence, cable, and T-posts
- Rock, concrete, masonry, and buried foundations
- Metal roofing, appliances, vehicle parts, and dumped household debris
- Utility markers, irrigation components, septic features, and shallow service lines
- Large dirt-packed root balls that accelerate wear and cut production

A site walk cannot eliminate every unknown. It converts hidden risk into a documented operating plan, which protects the property, the machine, and the price you were quoted.

A note on burn piles

Some landowners cut because they intend to burn. Burning is a legitimate land-management tool, but it is not an automatic substitute for mulching and it is not a disposal shortcut. Research comparing mastication against slash-pile burning in pinyon-juniper woodland found substantially greater soil degradation and poorer soil biological condition on pile-burn areas than on untreated or masticated plots [7]. If burning is part of the plan, it needs to be planned — for fuel condition, weather, permitting, county burn restrictions, safety, and the actual management objective.

When pre-cutting does make sense

"Never cut first" is too absolute. Pre-cutting works when it is coordinated with the contractor:

- Removing a limited number of marked trees you want kept for posts, firewood, lumber, or habitat structures.
- Hand-clearing immediately around fragile improvements where machine access is restricted.
- Cutting material that exceeds the attachment's operating envelope, with a defined removal plan attached.
- Separating contaminated debris from clean vegetation before the machine arrives.
- Opening access needed by surveyors, utility locators, or emergency entry — after the route is jointly selected.

The rule is simple: coordinate first, cut second.

What to do instead

The cheapest preparation is not labor. It is information.

- Locate property corners, easements, utilities, septic components, wells, culverts, and known underground services.
- Flag the trees and habitat areas that must remain. Use consistent colors and explain the system on the walk.
- Photograph anything you are worried about, and hand over any surveys, plats, or utility maps you have.
- Write down the end state from Section 01.
- Leave the brush standing unless we specifically tell you otherwise.

05 What comes back, and when

This is the first question every landowner asks after a clearing job, and the honest answer has two parts.

A properly severed Ashe juniper is dead. It will not resprout [1][2][4]. What comes back is the next generation — seedlings already present in the soil, plus new seed arriving from nearby mature trees. Female junipers produce large quantities of berry-like cones, and birds and mammals distribute the seed across the property and in from the fence lines.

Texas Parks and Wildlife puts it plainly: because the soil is full of juniper seed, land in parts of the Hill Country is generally due for another treatment after roughly seven to eight years [1]. Treat that as a planning reference, not a guarantee. Visible seedlings show up considerably sooner, and the right maintenance trigger is density and land use, not the calendar.

After treatment	What is likely happening	What you should be doing
0–12 months	Treated cedar stays dead. Hidden seedlings become visible as light reaches the ground. Grasses and forbs respond if moisture and grazing pressure allow.	Inspect treatment quality, protect the grass response, establish photo points.
1–3 years	New seedlings establish from existing seed and nearby mature trees. Fast-growing grass hides small plants well.	Spot-remove seedlings while stems are small and cheap to treat.

After treatment	What is likely happening	What you should be doing
3–5 years	Untreated seedlings become easy to see and start occupying open space. Density climbs fast where ground cover is weak.	Move from casual observation to a scheduled annual inspection.
5–8 years	Without maintenance, cedar again becomes a real access, forage, and visibility problem. This is the window TPWD cites for general retreatment [1].	Selective follow-up now, before the site needs a full mechanical reset.
8+ years	A property with no follow-up trends back toward dense woody cover, fastest near seed sources and on poorly managed range.	Expect higher treatment intensity, more machine hours, and more usable ground lost.

Why it comes back

- **Seedbank and seed rain.** Mature female trees produce seed, and wildlife spreads it.
- **Untreated cedar nearby.** Fence lines, draws, neighboring acreage, and retained habitat patches stay continuous seed sources.
- **Fire suppression.** TPWD identifies the loss of recurring fire as the reason juniper spread out of steep draws and canyons and took the uplands. Cedar is not fire-tolerant; frequent pre-settlement fire held it in check [1].
- **Weak grass competition.** Overgrazing, exposed soil, drought stress, and repeated disturbance open the door for woody seedlings.
- **No maintenance trigger.** Most landowners wait until the property looks thick again — which converts cheap seedling control into another capital project.

The number that should change how you think about this

Ashe juniper is slow to rebuild when the seed source is genuinely gone. On the Edwards Plateau, one study found a total of six juniper saplings and no mature trees across burned transects ten years after fire, against 646 to 871 trees per hectare in nearby unburned areas [4]. Fire is a different tool than a mulcher and carries its own planning requirements — but the contrast makes the economics clear. Cedar does not rebound quickly on its own. It rebounds because seed keeps arriving and because nothing removed the seedlings while they were small.

The other half of the leverage: a female Ashe juniper takes roughly ten to twenty years to mature and begin producing seed of its own [2]. Every seedling you pull with loppers this spring is a seed factory that never opens.

06 What mulch does — and what it does not

You will see the claim that a mulch layer suppresses regrowth and improves the soil. It is more complicated than that, and a contractor who tells you otherwise is selling.

A moderate, evenly distributed layer can protect soil, moderate temperature, and hold moisture. Heavy, concentrated mats are a different story. In pinyon-juniper and lodgepole systems, mulch thicker than about three inches depressed herbaceous plant cover and soil nitrogen availability [8]. Broader assessments across western ecosystems found the effects do not generalize: in some systems mulch had no measurable impact

on herbaceous cover or seedling regeneration, and in others it reduced soil nitrogen and seedling regeneration while increasing herbaceous cover [8].

Two practical conclusions. First, mulch depth and distribution are operator decisions that matter, especially around the trunks of trees you are paying to keep. Second, nobody should promise you that mulch will hold cedar back. Those studies are from western forest and woodland systems, not the Edwards Plateau, and the Forest Service is explicit that mastication outcomes depend on objectives, slope, soil vulnerability, invasive-species risk, biomass configuration, and operator skill [5][6].

STRAIGHT ANSWER

Forestry mulching removes and reduces standing woody vegetation and puts the processed biomass on the ground. It improves access, opens canopy, exposes terrain you could not see, and creates the conditions for follow-up management.

It does not sterilize soil and it does not prevent germination. Manage your property on what you see in the field, not on a claim that mulch is universally good or universally harmful.

07 Before you clear mature woodland: the warbler

This section exists because most contractors will not raise it, and it carries more risk than anything else in this guide.

The golden-cheeked warbler is federally listed as endangered and breeds nowhere on earth except Central Texas. It nests in Ashe juniper and oak woodland, and the female weaves the nest from strips of Ashe juniper bark [9][10]. Bell, Coryell, and Lampasas are all among the counties with known breeding populations, and the northern segment of designated critical habitat covers all three [10][11]. Fort Hood, spanning Coryell and Bell, holds one of only a handful of significant protected populations [12]. Before the 1990 listing, the leading cause of habitat loss was juniper clearing [12].

TPWD is direct that mature cedar is warbler habitat and recommends a holistic, property-specific approach rather than indiscriminate removal [1]. Dense young cedar monoculture and mature juniper-oak woodland in a canyon or draw are not the same thing ecologically, and they should not be treated as the same thing operationally.

What this means for your project

- Nesting season runs roughly March through August. Clearing mature juniper-oak woodland during that window carries the most exposure.
- Dense regrowth cedar in an old pasture is a different conversation than tall, mature juniper mixed with oak in a canyon or along a drainage.
- If mature woodland is in scope, that gets evaluated before the machine is scheduled — with the right professionals, which may include a TPWD biologist or a qualified consultant.
- This is a real legal question, not a formality. Nothing in this guide is legal advice, and CHEW is not a substitute for a wildlife biologist or an attorney.

We would rather have this conversation at the estimate than after the fact. It is also worth saying plainly: keeping mature cedar is often the right call for reasons that have nothing to do with regulation — privacy, screening, shade, slope protection, and wildlife. Retain it on purpose, and control expansion into the areas you actually need.

08 Clear & Keep: the maintenance math

The economic mistake is treating cedar management as a one-time purchase. Clearing is not a permanent solution. It is the reset button. Land that stays open is land that gets periodic attention.

Stage	Typical condition	Right response	Cost exposure
Reset	Dense established cedar limits access or land use	Mechanical treatment matched to the property objective	Highest
Stabilize	Open ground, scattered seedlings, variable grass response	Annual inspection, grazing control, selective seedling removal	Low to moderate
Maintain	Seedlings treated before they establish canopy	Routine spot work and periodic professional review	Lowest
Reset again	Maintenance deferred until woody cover returns	Second mechanical reset	High again

The five-part plan

1. Establish photo points. Fixed positions, same direction, same time of year, every year. This is the cheapest management tool you will ever use.
2. Inspect in late winter or early spring, when evergreen cedar seedlings stand out against dormant vegetation. Remember the awl-shaped seedling foliage from Section 02.
3. Set a density trigger. Not a feeling that the place is getting thick — a defined threshold by trail, pasture, homesite, fence line, or acre.
4. Protect the grass recovery. Avoid grazing pressure or traffic that strips the site right after treatment. Continuous grass cover is the best natural defense you have against seedlings.
5. Retain cedar intentionally, not accidentally. Keep the mature stands that serve a purpose. Control the expansion into the ground you need.

Small seedlings come out with loppers, hand pulling, targeted individual-plant treatment, mowing where appropriate, or carefully planned fire under qualified management. Once stems are dense and woody, you are back to buying horsepower and production hours. That is the entire argument for Clear & Keep: a scheduled return visit costs a fraction of a second reset, and it means you never start from a wall of cedar again.

09 Questions to ask any contractor

Including us. If a contractor cannot answer these, that tells you something.

- What material can your machine process safely and efficiently, and what has to be removed, staged, hauled, or handled another way?
- How will you protect the trees I am keeping, and how will you avoid concentrating mulch around their trunks?
- How do slope, soil moisture, rock, access, and hidden debris affect your production plan on my property specifically?

- What conditions could change the price or the schedule after work starts, and how does that get approved?
 - What is explicitly not included — stump removal, hauling, grading, seeding, permitting, utility locating, survey, burn work?
 - What will this property need in year two, year five, and year eight?
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One problem. One call. One solution.

CHEW provides land clearing, forestry mulching, stump grinding, and gravel driveway work for Central Texas property owners around Copperas Cove, including projects in Coryell, Bell, and Lampasas Counties, subject to access, scope, equipment fit, and scheduling. Call for a free on-site estimate, or send photos to start.

www.CallChew.com · 737-235-1335

Sources and Technical References

Equipment capability and ecological outcomes vary by carrier machine, attachment, operator, vegetation, terrain, soil, weather, and objective. Several soil and mulch studies cited here were conducted in western forest and woodland systems rather than on the Edwards Plateau; they are directionally useful, not locally definitive.

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- [3] Biology and Ecology of Ashe Juniper. Texas Natural Resources Server, Texas A&M. texnat.tamu.edu — source of the dioecious habit, cone maturation, and the scale-like vs. awl-shaped foliage distinction.
- [4] *Juniperus ashei* species account, The Gymnosperm Database. conifers.org — including Reemts and Hansen (2008), Edwards Plateau post-fire regeneration counts.
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- [6] Is Mastication Right for Your Site? Science-Based Decision Trees for Forest Managers. USDA Forest Service. research.fs.usda.gov
- [7] Above- and Belowground Responses to Tree Thinning Depend on the Treatment of Tree Debris. USDA Forest Service / Forest Ecology and Management. research.fs.usda.gov
- [8] Battaglia, M., Rhoades, C., Rocca, M., Ryan, M. A Regional Assessment of the Ecological Effects of Chipping and Mastication Fuels Reduction and Forest Restoration Treatments. Joint Fire Science Program / USDA Forest Service. research.fs.usda.gov — source of the mulch-depth threshold and the finding that responses do not generalize across ecosystems.
- [9] Golden-cheeked Warbler species account. Texas Parks and Wildlife Department. tpwd.texas.gov/huntwild/wild/species/gcw
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- [12] Golden-cheeked Warbler status and recovery documentation. U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service. ecos.fws.gov
- [13] Brush Management Conservation Practice Standard (Code 314). USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service — use the Texas Field Office Technical Guide for local planning.
- [14] Juniper Biology and Management in Texas. Texas A&M AgriLife Extension.